

Two Brotherhoods in the Same Neighborhood: Muslim-Christian Relations among the Yorubas in Southwest Nigeria. *

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Abstract

For so long, the co-existence and relations between Christians and Muslims among Yorubas have become an emblem of praise and accolades for an ethnic group that has almost an equal proportion of people in the two faiths. It is against this backdrop that this reflection seeks to draw inferences from the lenses of different strands of literature on Muslim-Christian relations among the Yoruba ethnic group domiciled in the Southwestern part of Nigeria. In the quest to inquire into the dynamics of co-existence of this culturally unique people in a religio-polemical society, this reflection avoids oversimplifying the interaction ensemble by the two Abrahamic religions. Rather, it approaches this subject by understanding the complexities and multidimensional layers of this interaction from the point of view of community organization and realities,

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focusing on the lived experiences of the people, the daily politics of engagement, and how the relationship is managed. Therefore, moving from presumptive guesses to factual assessment, this study has been able to situate this relation beyond peaceful coexistence and tolerance rhetoric to an intersectionality of 'culturalness' and the humanness of Yoruba heritage. From the findings, the Christian–Muslim relations do not obviate the existence of friction or a conflict of interest. What is remarkable is how these differences are managed as well as how these dynamics play out as they go about their daily lives. More importantly, this relation is observed to evolve in time and should be explained and examined as an evolutionary process of shifting dynamics rather than a given.

Keywords: Muslim-Christian relations, lived religion, Southwestern Yorubaland, Yorubas, Abrahamic religions, religion-culture tradeoff

1 Background

As the notable world religions continue to spread by and large, religious pluralism is taking on a new shade of complex interaction and intersectionality. Getting it right from the onset, Soares (2016) will argue that religious pluralism is not just the existence of different religious traditions in one space; he explains it further to examine the multiplicity of practices, not exempting the possibilities of personal pluralism of individuals or groups engaging in different religions or religious practices. Yet, in the long history of religious studies, both possibilities are being achieved at various levels, most especially in the study of the Abrahamic religions, particularly, Islam and Christianity. However, studies on the encounters of these two religions, the lived religion and interaction within a space, have not made much scholarship, particularly in Africa, where these two religions coexist remarkably across vast boundaries and societies in contemporary times (Peel, 2016; Soares,

2016; Walls, 1999).

Even so, the growing number of scholarships that attempted to examine Muslim-Christian relations did so along a conflictual or political divide, in which case, the opposite, that is, non-conflictual, will normatively investigate mutual co-existence within the narrative of tolerance. As I. Nolte *et al.*, (2016) and Soares (2016) contended, exploring this subject along the parallel of coexistence and conflict is misleading and reduces the impulse of the robust and dynamic interaction embedded in such a relation. Hence, offering a broader perspective to this thesis avoids the error of analyzing these religions in isolation—the distinctive parallel of tolerance or conflict—but jointly as lived religion interacting dynamically over time (I. Nolte, 2020).

The continent of Africa particularly fields a plethora of substance to the Christian-Muslim relations discourse, considering the growing prominence and dominance of the two religions within its borders. Compared to others, Muslim-Christian relations in other parts of the world can be unevenly asymmetric. Take for instance, societies in the Middle East that are rapidly Muslim-dominated with gradually eroding Christian communities. On the other hand, if not migration that propels Muslim society in Europe, the continent over many centuries had been a base for Christians (Peel, 2016, p 124). Apart from migration, the other dynamic responsible for a mixed community of Christian and Muslim is conversion, a major factor responsible for the proliferation of these two Abrahamic religions in Africa, where, until their presence, there had been an existing indigenous religion.

This was the case for the growing influence of Islam and Christianity in Nigeria and specifically in Southwestern Nigeria, renowned as the cradle of the Yoruba ethnic group. While Islam and Christianity in Nigeria are divided along the North-South divide, respectively, the Southwestern part of the country is famous for its almost even composition of Muslims and Christians (Williams, 2021). Most towns and villages have considerable followers of both religions. Not only that, just as I. Nolte (2020) rightly noted, there exists fluidity

in social relations between the two; shared space, shared family history, and many times borrowings, interfaith marriages, marked sociocultural participation, and corporate social lives are critical ingredients of this marked relation dynamics between Muslims and Christians in Yorubaland.

Often, the line of research is blurred on the inter-relations of religion within a religiously heterogeneous society, particularly in a situation where there is no majority or minority group. Notably, the Yorubas in the Southwestern part of Nigeria uniquely depict this kind of setting. Since this pattern of relation and coexistence can be dated for over a century now, the relation is worth studying, and if anything at all, the changing dynamics of this relation are a critical component worth investigating, particularly as society keeps evolving.

It is on this foundation that this reflection seeks to study the lived religion of Muslims and Christians of Yorubaland, taking a cursory glance into the etymology of this relation, examining the religion-society mix, and pontificating into the coexistence and conflict symphony. Also, drawing on existing scholarship, the reflection will investigate the dynamic Muslim-Christian relation among the Yorubas to see whether it is culturally given or normatively contingent.

2 Trace to the root

Although both Christianity and Islam are considered proportionate in the religious milieu of contemporary Yoruba society and culture, the existence of one predates the other in the region. Existing records show that Islam was already introduced to northern Nigeria as early as the 11th century, with a domino effect of its expansion trickling down to the southwestern part of the country, particularly Yorubaland, in the 16th century. Although not until the 19th century did Islam start attracting significant numbers of Yorubas (I. Nolte,

2020; Peel, 2016). More specifically, it is on record that Islam came to the Southwestern Yoruba-speaking region during the time of Mansa Musa of the Mali Empire (Ottuh *et al.*, 2014; Jones, 2005). The more reason Islamic religion has been referred to over the years as “*Esin ‘mole*”, which is colloquially derived from the Yoruba word for religion, which is “*Esin*” and the “*imole*” connoting that which belongs to Malians. Historically, this was before the advent of colonization.

On the other hand, Christianity, the second largest religion in the country according to CIA World Factbook (2021), expanded rapidly in Nigeria during the 19th century by missionaries and freed slaves, and particularly started its spread to other parts of the country from the Southwest (Peel, 2016; Soares, 2016; Ajayi, 1966, p 126,). Before this "modern expansion", as some scholars put it, history had it that Christianity, specifically Catholicism, was already introduced in the ancient Benin and Warri Kingdom as far back as the 15th century, but it was not sustained (Ajayi, 1966). Not until the 19th century was Christianity established in the country, and by the end of the century, the two world religions had gained ground massively through conversion. According to Peel (2016, p 126), nearly 90 percent of Yorubas in the southwest had become Muslims or Christians in the early 1950s. This narrative speaks for the emergence of the two world religions in Yorubaland, but a more striking scenario will be the next-to-equal representation of these religions in the region, which is a distinctive feature that cannot be obtained in other regions of the country where one is either the majority and the other is the minority.

In addition, Islam already had an established stronghold in northern Nigeria through the Caliphate crusade, extending its influence southward until Ilorin, the capital of Kwara state. This explains why Kwara State, arguably an extension of the Yoruba descendants, is Muslim-dominated and will not fit into the scope of this Southwest dynamic of Muslim-Christian relations. But perhaps from a geographical perspective too, although Kwara State is considered a state within Western Nigeria, it is not classified as part of the Southwest as shown in the 1 below. Even though the state shares borders with three states,

namely, Oyo, Osun and Ekiti, within the geopolitical zoning in the country, Kwara sits in the North Central. Additionally, as noted by I. Nolte *et al.*, (2016), there is a significant proportion of non-Yoruba-speaking populace in Kwara state compared to those observed in the other states that constitute Yorubaland. Hence, Kwara state would have offered a skewed narrative of the Muslim-Christian proportion in Yorubaland, as opposed to South-western Nigeria.

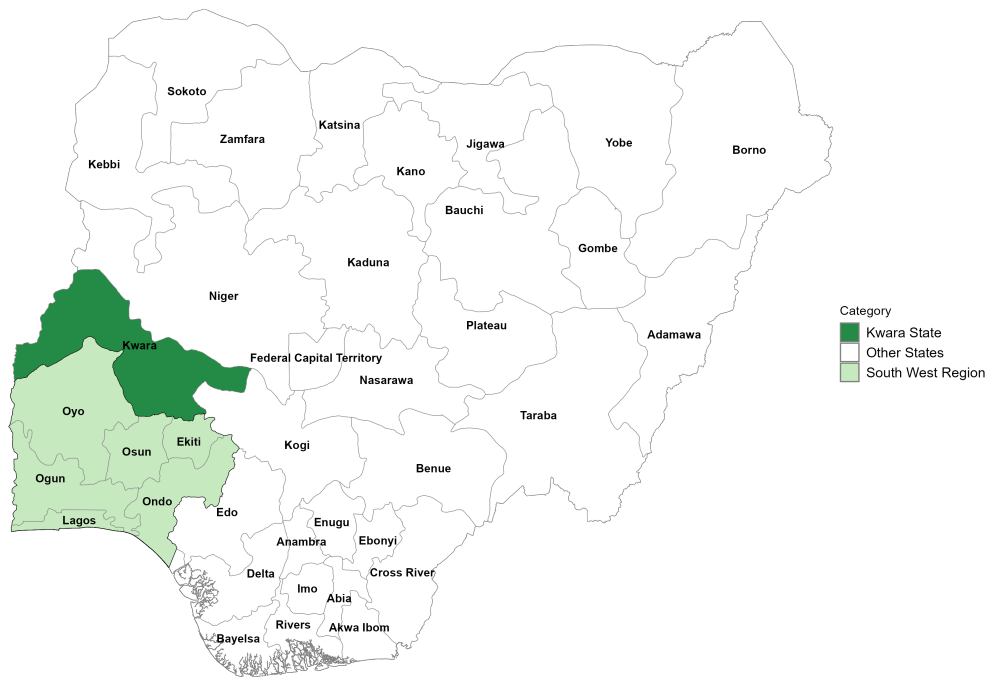


Figure 1: Map of Nigeria showing the Southwest region and Kwara State [Author's compilation]

As more and more converts of Islam and Christianity continue to flood the southwest region—the cradle of Yoruba culture and society, the two dynamic entities continue to deepen its influence while constantly in contact with each other, working and reworking modalities around their social interaction and coexistence. With the determination to perpetuate history, Peel (2016, p 124) suggests that whatever outcome is achieved is driven by the contribution of each religion to the Yoruba situation from its own past and

actualized by the agency of individuals and collectives. This process, initiated first by self-realization and strong attachment to the socio-cultural rituals of community belonging, is engendered in the Yoruba analogy of “*omo iya mi*”, which means, children of the same mother (Peel, 2016, p 126). This ideological stance, more or less belief, explicates this relatedness as congenial. That is, regardless of religious preference, the people themselves belong to the same mother, in this case, Yoruba.

Along this same rhetoric, M. I. Nolte *et al.*, (2018) reified the fundamental belief upheld by Yorubas, which is the knowledge that “*Olodumare*” sourced them and, by this, it is believed that all Yorubas come from *Olodumare*—the equivalent of God as widely used. Usually, a potential level ground exists to situate the Yorubas at the centre of a longstanding communal heritage, irrespective of religious affiliations. This is built around the concept of community referred to as “*ilu*”, which predates the colonial administrative division and stratification. This community, as conceived by scholars, transcends a mere geographical mapping of a people. In this case, the longitude and latitude are the people. Fayemi (2009) and Gyekye (1996, p 35) construe it as a social-political arrangement whose mainstream is people or a group of people linked together by interpersonal bonds. This interpersonal bond—not necessarily biological—is however predicated on the agency of social being and belonging to some set of values; most significantly, communal.

Not different from what is obtainable in a typical African traditional society, communalism is nucleated at the very fabric of the Yoruba culture (Fayemi, 2009). Further diagnostics reveal that this creates, one, a sense of belonging and secondly, that of responsibility to corporate values and ideals. On this foundation lies the compass that shows the principles of social relations as well as guides behavioral and attitudinal composure regardless of religious affinity. Its onions include *inter alia*, social responsibility, mutual trust, harmony, decorum, care, solidarity, reciprocity, and interdependence (Oyeshile, 2006, p 104). Among the Yorubas, the framework of “*ilu*” is hierarchically structured along this division of subtribal levels (Ijesha, Ijebu, Ekiti, Oyo, Egba, Ilaje, etc.) to historic communities

or towns, then down to a more discrete level—the family clan.

While much emphasis had been placed on communal values, at the unit level of individuality is another important phenomenon called “*Omoluwabi*”—a marker of cultural probity in Yorubaland. “*Omoluwabi*” could offer a plausible explanation for the kind of relationship that exists between Muslims and Christians of Yoruba descent. Essentially, it is a compound for character worthiness and moral rectitude. Fayemi (2009) described it as a conglomeration of principles of moral conduct, and its offspring include, but are not limited to, respect, truth, character, bravery, hard work, intelligence, articulate oration, among others. In the school of morals, which supposedly should begin at the family level, as the saying goes, charity begins at home—every child is expected to be taught as well as imbibe the principles of “*omoluwabi*”. In fact, the commendation “*omoluwabi*” should be a corollary to exemplifying a worthy character outside. Sequel to these characteristics and shared similarities, especially within the communal framework, each religion is expected to manage its differences and competition as they interchange between themselves (Peel, 2016, p 126).

3 The Mix

Beyond the conflict-tolerance parallel, a paradigm shift in nuance to the dynamics of lived religion will unearth the nitty-gritty of multireligious encounter, in this case, Muslim-Christian relations among the Yorubas in Southwest Nigeria, and at the same time offer a more robust exegesis on the form of exchange and relations. Arguably, the two world religions are not just strongly established in Yorubaland; both have a long history of mingling, exchanging, borrowing, and resembling (Soares, 2016). The everyday polity, engagements and identification in the typical Yoruba society are drawn along religious affiliations, and denying this fact in the name of peace might be the catalyst for unprecedented clashes. In what Ottuh *et al.*, (2014) appended to be a ‘battle of supremacy’, the reality is that the con-

testation to dominate is not an exclusive rule of any specific religion. In fact, it transcends just the religious sphere.

Historically, not until the earlier decades of colonial rule did the growing influence of the two faiths intersect, particularly in Lagos, the heart of colonial administration. From the 1840s, the first five decades of Islam and Christianity in Yorubaland witnessed a modicum of encounter and influence between the two because the indigenous traditional religion was still very much in vogue (Peel, 2016, p 174). Hence, the entire Yoruba populace in the Southwest region was divided among Islam, Christianity, and what is popularly referred to as African Traditional Religion (ATR). But the massive conversion that will later sweep across the region created more impact on the two world religions.

Gradually, Western education increased the encounter when Islam started to adopt western-style schooling provided by the colonial rule, predominantly, Christian-led mission education. As I. Nolte *et al.*, (2016) rightly noted, although the ensuing universal primary education was a secular policy, the dominance of mission education, however, encouraged conversion since the teachers were mostly Christians. Later on, the Muslim-Christian relation will be replete with borrowings and appropriations between them; for instance, the case of Pentecostalism in Christianity— a semblance of which is NASFAT in Islam, that is, Pentecostalism is to Christianity what NASFAT is to Islam. According to Soares (2016), it will be unsurprising if NASFAT is referred to as ‘Islamic Pentecostalism’ or ‘Pentecostal Islam’. Similarly, Peel (2016, p 176) will argue that the observance of night vigils is a practice Christians borrowed from Muslims, and the same goes for the imitation of pilgrimage by Christians. Furthermore, Peel (2016, p 175) will contend that the distinctive Yoruba-styled mosque architecture from the 1920s was reconciled with Christian architectural forms with characteristics of Gothic windows, twin western towers, pillared naves and so on—although it was reported to have lasted till the 1980s.

Furthermore, the concept of power and politics offer a nuanced perspective on the rela-

tions between Christians and Muslims in Yorubaland. Arguably, the quest for power and politics wields the greatest influence and is a huge determinant of the nature and kind of relations that exist between Muslims and Christians within the same space. As Soares (2016) asserted, these two need to be understood in broader terms from micro and everyday politics in specific social (at the grassroots) to institutional politics in formal settings such as political parties, elections, general assemblies and so on. Notably, the dynamism in Muslim-Christian relations has undergone different phases politically. Long before now, the disposition of Christians to politics was rather livid; a puritanical proponent of separating the things of God from the world. Exclusively, it was a lullaby of, 'give unto Caesar what belongs to Caesar', or 'politics is a dirty game'. According to Peel (2016, p 111), the result of this was an early formation among the politically marginalised.

Today, the narrative has changed. Interestingly, also, at the microlevel, politics observed within the Yoruba community, association and social relations are organized on an alternate policy for rotational representation. If it is Muslim first, Christian will be next, and vice versa. Or, for instance, when a Muslim is President, there is every possibility that the office of the General Secretary is reserved for the 'other' religion, which in this case is Christian and vice versa. This is a common routine (sometimes unwritten) in the politics of representation in associations, unions, cooperatives, organisations, social functions, community groups and so on. Usually, disagreement or even conflict often erupt when one of the two religions try to alter, breach, or circumvent this system. Unequivocally, as of today, this is a major catalyst for friction and conflict between the religions.

The reality sheet of the lived relations between the two religions is further consolidated at the level of interfaith marriages; people get married across both religions, sometimes, not without restrictions. More so, the shared semblance in both social and religious rituals – some of which include naming ceremony, marriage, freedom, graduation, burial, etc. – constantly creates a convergence for mingling and sharing. On the other hand, relatives, friends, and families gather to celebrate during festivities – Christmas and Ileya

alike (Peel, 2016, p 134). While this is a common place within the Yoruba community, the narrative will be skewed if the exceptions are underscored. Existing within this same community are people who may associate with the 'other' at the sociocultural level, take for instance, a naming ceremony, wedding or burial, but will not associate with religious festivities. Hence, reducing Muslim-Christian relations and encounters among the Yorubas in southwestern Nigeria on peaceful coexistence and tolerance will be limiting.

4 The peaceful coexistence symphony

Almost every time, studies around multi-religious relations have been dissected along the parallel of peaceful coexistence or conflict, even though it is limiting in fully articulating the dynamics of interrelations in religious pluralism. Suffice it to say that this inclination is partly justified, considering the persistent clash and growing tensions between the two world religions in what Huntington (1993) referred to as the "clash of civilizations". Muslim-Christian encounters over the years have been replete with constant friction, at times full blown crisis. According to Ottuh *et al.*, (2014), the constant friction and tension are attributed to what they termed as the evil of bigotry, fanaticism, intolerance, ignorance and exclusivism. And where the encounter is non-conflictual, the debate on the nature of the relations hovers around peaceful coexistence or tolerance (I. Nolte, 2020; Forst, 2004). In the case of the Yorubas, despite establishing that there is almost an equal proportion of Muslims and Christians, the region has recorded very little religious conflict, particularly in the 20th and 21st centuries (I. Nolte, 2020).

Apparently, the seeming mutual engagement between Muslims and Christians among the Yorubas in the Southwest ascribed the honorary peace badge to the region and people as exceptionally tolerant of religious differences (I. Nolte, 2020; Peel, 2016). Even the former President of Nigeria, Goodluck Ebele Jonathan attested to this while addressing the growing concern on security and instability in the country in recent times. In his address at the

13th Joe-Kyari Public lecture, as reported by This Day on 23rd June 2021, captioned, 'Re-defining Democracy: Yearnings of the Minority in a Democratic Setting', the former president said, "Aside from the Southwest (the cradle of Yorubas), no other area in the country has been able to balance religion and development. This is the only part of the country where we feel has been able to manage religion and development very well" ¹. Consolidating the consistency of this relation, the now former President had earlier mentioned this in April 2014, when as an incumbent, the President encouraged other geopolitical zones in the country to emulate the religious tolerance among the states in the Southwest. As reported by Vanguard newspaper, seven years before, President Goodluck Jonathan said, "if the people of Southwest could live with another despite the population of Muslims and Christians", he saw no reason for religious violence in any part of the country ².

The Yorubas pride in this mutual engagement as a corollary of their rich cultural heritage, which is long ingrained in its communal ideology. While some scholars also alluded to this relation as culturally given, others see it as an ongoing historical achievement. However, conceptualizing this subject as a 'field', Janson and Meyer (2016) describe this religious coexistence as a shifting dynamic of similarity and difference. Explaining further this dynamic relation among the Yorubas, Peel (2016) contended in his work that,

The complex of forces of attraction and repulsion that is the Yoruba religious field may thus be viewed from three different angles. Each hinges on a particular key factor—community values, the ideological thrust of the world religions, the pragmatic values imposed on religions as they compete for popular favor—that sets limits to the historical working out of the other factors. (Page 172).

Deductively, the Muslim-Christian relation among the Yorubas in Southwest Nigeria re-

¹See former president Goodluck Jonathan's statement about the Yorubas on religious relation in this release, <https://www.thisdaylive.com/index.php/2021/06/23/jonathan-inability-to-manage-nigerias-diversity-cause-of-growing-tensions/>

²See also <https://www.vanguardngr.com/2014/04/jonathan-tasks-nigerians-religious-tolerance/>

volves around the circus of community ethos, values, and the ideological thrusts of the Yoruba Muslims and Christians. An indication that the dynamic Muslim-Christian relations is a network of exchange and variance that transcends a mere presence or absence of conflict. Just like Huntington hypothesized, in all encounters and engagements, conflict of interest is unavoidable. And when this happens, if both parties comply by the rules of engagement entrenched in the fundamental value of shared humanity, potential escalations could be averted. So, the thrust is the inclination to shared *Yorubanness* rather than religious affiliation. Moreover, the attention will then shift to how this relation continues to thrive, especially in the wake of the emergence of radical Islamic reformist and neo-Pentecostalism in the region in recent times.

Fundamentally, the potential for both Muslim and Christian relations among the Yorubas is often ascribed to the assimilation of cultural values vis-à-vis shared identity, which then pervades the way religion is interpreted (M. I. Nolte *et al.*, 2018). In fact, the concept of “*omo iyami*” as earlier discussed could be seen as a predicator to acknowledging in two folds, a common descent and then, the evolution of both religion from Abraham. And so, it could be interpreted to mean that the religion is related on one hand, whilst the other stands in anecdotal coherence to shared identity. As a result of this, by and large, it is common to hear the clause, ‘we serve the same God’ among both religious faithful, maybe not all, but very common. This, particularly, is an existential debate that has been subjected to various scrutiny with heightened attention and intensity in recent years, resulting in myriad debates, fora, and symposiums to either discredit this belief or corroborate it.

The grousing ambivalence of the commonality or the rejection of it, and much more the tendency to engage in such debates, cannot be dissociated from the growing regime of Islamic reformist and neo-Pentecostalism. On both sides of the divide, the subjectivity of the differing interpretations is largely dependent on several factors, the underlying factor being the leader or preacher, followed by other factors such as doctrines, ideologies, philosophies, cultural affinity, religious dispositions, exposures, education, etc. Pro-

foundly, external influences and inclinations outside the cultural (Yoruba) milieu could also be responsible for the acceptance or rejection of such a belief.

Furthermore, the absence of evidence is not the evidence of absence, implying that, even in the light of this revelation on the kind of relation that exists between Muslims and Christians in the southwestern part of Nigeria, conflict or friction is inevitable. Most importantly, recent tides of events continue to cast a shadow on the dynamics of the peaceful coexistence tides. But the intriguing part, nevertheless, which also conforms with the peculiarity of this relation, is that, if anything, the swift response, sensitivity and awareness to varying conflict situations is still unmatched. When interrogated, Ombugadu *et al.*, (2021) found out that the past is the compass for the present; the ugly experience of the past guides the management of such contentions, as those with historical facts are constrained to mediate in order to avoid a recurrence. For instance, there have been contentions recently on the use of Hijab by female Muslims in schools, regardless of whether it is an Islamic school or not ³. Some Islamic group calls for the recognition and legitimisation of the Hijab as part of the school uniform, while certain Christian groups see no reason why the existing pattern should be altered, also due to the fact that there are other alternatives, that is, schools that recognise Hijab as part of their uniform.

This contention is not just in prominent cities like Lagos or Ibadan, the intricacies of this are also immanent in remote communities. In fact, recently in Ilorin, it degenerated into a micro conflict which was quickly de-escalated with the intervention of the state ⁴. And hence, for the umpteenth time, it is yet uncertain whether these addenda and reforms are gradually expunging the liberal tendencies surrounding the harmonious relationship that had long existed between the two religions. Or a more pragmatic enquiry will be to ascertain which capital contributes more to the supposed peaceful coexistence between Muslims and Christians in Yorubaland, the historic religious antecedents, or communal

³See Vanguard (2019): <https://www.vanguardngr.com/2019/01/why-the-hate-about-muslim-students-in-hijab/>

⁴See Punch (2021): <https://punchng.com/yoruba-muslims-vs-yoruba-chris>

values? And the more important question would be what the future holds, factoring in the changing dynamics.

As the population increases, Yoruba communities have been organizing and re-organizing themselves in a very distinct and dynamic way (Ojo-Fajuru *et al.*, 2018; Bascom, 1962). The expansion of settlement, which could be attributed to urbanism, also contributes to the shifting dynamic of Muslim – Christian relations among the Yorubas. Exploring randomly prominent cities in the region, major cosmopolitan areas that will make the list include urban and central capitals like Lagos, Abeokuta, Ibadan, Osogbo, Akure, and Ado Ekiti. However, as far back as 1962, Bascom (1962) contended that, even in the pre- and post-colonial era, the Yorubas lived in ‘city-like’ areas, remarkably enlisting them among the most urbanized people in Africa. However, the influence of culture in shaping settlement patterns has not been the subject of many studies or perhaps underscored as Olayiwola *et al.*, (2014) also argued. In recent developments, apart from factors—such as socioeconomic activities, political fragmentation, industrialization, urbanization, and so on—that change settlements spatially with time, Ombugadu *et al.*, (2021) as identified among other factors, the influence of both culture and religion. Both factors, however, offer a rich insight into the thesis on the contemporary dynamics around Muslim – Christian relations among the Yorubas.

The study by Olayiwola *et al.*, (2014) on the physical growth pattern of settlements in a traditional region, southwestern Nigeria, pointed out that settlements are more aggregated in bigger townships and metropolises. By implication, physical connectedness as well as contact is preserved with the ‘other’—a similitude of the ‘big-compound-settlement’ arrangement in a typical Yoruba society of a few decades ago. On the other hand, they found out that in smaller townships, settlements are less aggregated with a very low degree of physical connectedness. More so, the latter is an indication of the potential for new neighbourhoods to spring up. But from observation, emerging new areas in these smaller townships are sometimes clustered around religious semblance. Unlike conventional names

like *Sango*, *Mokola*, *Challenge* and more indigenous names like *Irewole*, *Isokan*, *Suurulere*, we now have names like *New Heaven*, *Medinah Area*, *Al-Hikmah*, *New Jerusalem*, *Canaan land*, *Oke Arafa*, etc.

This was, in fact, the bane of a mild religious crisis in some communities around the *Oke Ogun* region of Oyo State. A newly colonized area was named by one of the religions on the claim that their facility was the first to be located in the area. However, the expansionary effects of settlement extension gradually witnessed the emergence of residents who later opposed the name because it was *ex parte* (one-sided), and on the contrary, they subscribed to the 'other' religion. This led to a conflict which escalated into a surrogate conundrum in which Christians will not buy from Muslims at the markets, and vice versa or commercial transport workers will not take a differing religious faithful, even though they are going to pay for the service. Again, for some reason, unless mediated by circumstances around affordability or some other exogenous factors, each will flock to their own in the choice or consideration of a new settlement. Implying that, provided circumstances around the choice of where to go remain uninfluenced, Yoruba Christians are likely opting for a Christian-dominated neighborhood, ditto for the Yoruba Muslims.

In the end, looking at these different dynamics, scholars who construed the relations that exist between Muslims and Christians among the Yorubas as culturally given will be ticking the necessary condition, but would not nullify those who assessed the relation as an ongoing historical achievement.

5 Conclusion

From all indications, Muslim-Christian relations among the Yorubas of southwest Nigeria is multifaceted, fitting into a network of significantly dependent factors. All evidence pointed to the shared Yoruba-ness of the people, adherence to communal identity as well

as shared humanity, which is considered to be more important than religious differences. By implication, the culture-religion tradeoff margin among Yoruba is narrow considering family relations and ties between Muslims and Christians, allowing for individual decision and right to choices. This can also be plausible in explaining the possibility of inter-faith marriages and less violent persecution when there is a conversion from Christianity to Islam and vice versa. Notably, states in the Southwest are not polarized along a religious divide—an enviable social demographic that could necessitate mingling and contact, unlike what is obtainable in the middle belt and the northern part of the country, where the two religions coexist. For instance, Jos Plateau is riddled between a predominantly Muslim North and mostly Christian South (Krause, 2011), and the same can be said of northern and southern Kaduna.

Notably, the tolerance crusade among Yorubas has been explicated at various levels of interactions within the community. For example, Muslims cope with the blaring speakers from Sunday services and occasional night vigils, while Christians also endure the blasting sounds of the typical Ahuja speakers during praying hours and most especially the night vigils (*Laylat-al-Qadr*) in the season of Ramadan. And what is more interesting is that this has lasted for decades of co-existing. Usually, it is observed that when Christians are having rallies and gyrating, including traditional religious festivals, all music and playing stops at the sight of a mosque, whether it is prayer time or not. The same treatment is extended across boards.

Additionally, the quest for spiritual solutions to problems has seen Yorubas link Jerusalem and Mecca, as some Muslims consult churches or mountains for spiritual consultation; the same is said of some Christians who know all the coordinates to the *Alfa* that can help. Although, this is highly shunned by the different religions, this does not stop people from casting their faith where their lot stakes. Additionally, major crusades like that of Reinhard Bonnke witnessed massive attendance of Muslims who also shared testimonies of miracles like their Christian counterparts. In most social gatherings that involve the

'other' religion, the traditional opening and closing prayer observed at the beginning and end of gatherings respectively, always witness a binary, where each religion leads prayers at turn, or one religion opens while the other closes the meeting.

Moreover, there seems to be a cancer that is slowly but steadily threatening this compactness among the Yorubas. In recent times, we have people, even though culturally Yoruba, who are vocal about their allegiance to their religion without deference to the Yoruba culture. You hear statements like, 'my fellow religious devotee—regardless of ethnic or cultural affiliation—are more kinsmen than blood relations who do not practice the same religion.' *Ab initio*, distinctive of the Yorubas, the long history of engagement and contact from the grassroots level to the apex of more formal institutions used to be a level playing ground void of partisanship, sentiments, or prejudice. The unfolding escapade in recent times continues to invalidate the revered egalitarianism attributed to the Yorubas.

Either overtly or behind the scenes, it is becoming increasingly prominent to see critical decisions swing towards religious sentiment. It is becoming a natural bias to consider people based on their religious affiliations. "Does he/she belong to us?" is a common parlance that determines where decisions will head. As a result of this, many have been denied certain opportunities and privileges because, though they ticked the culture clause, they fall short of the religious one. For example, we are witnessing in real time, communities within Yorubaland that are without traditional rulers because of the religious affiliation of the next-in-line. This unbalanced power relation is a crisis fought without arms or clubs, but it wields the potential of widening the culture-religion tradeoff margin, which was otherwise envied by people of other cultures.

Generally, when examining the Muslim-Christian relation, most especially drawing from the realities of the Yorubas in southwestern Nigeria, it would be limiting to take a cursory reflection from the peaceful coexistence and tolerance rhetoric as extant studies have explored. This is because the dynamic relation transcends the presence or absence of con-

flict and offers a rich exegesis of 'culturalness' intersected with humaneness and how this has been exported into the way religion is practised. Although conflict is inevitable, the strength of these two relations, however, lies in their ability to manage their differences. More importantly, this dynamic relation should be seen and explained beyond a given but as an evolutionary process of shifting dynamics and hence, more attention should be placed on exploring the temporality of Muslim-Christian relations among the Yorubas.

6 Reflexivity

The author is a Christian and has a paternal grandmother who is a Muslim. One of his four uncles is a Muslim, and a large extended family with both Christian and Muslim adherents.

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